UN Conference on Environment

Stockholm, 1972

The liberation of Bangladesh in December 1971 and the India-Pakistan Summit and Agreement in Simla in July 1972 overshadow India's participation at the UN Conference on the Human Environment in Sweden in June 1972. As climate change now dominates global agendas, the position India then took was paradigmatic for the Global South as a whole. By coining the phrase 'Poverty is the greatest polluter', PM **Indira Gandhi** articulated a developing country's perspective and underlined that economic development of the Global South and environment protection would have to be an integrated process.



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Resetting China Ties

Beijing, 1988

Rajiv Gandhi's prime ministerial visit to Beijing in December 1988 changed the Indo-China relationship. The territorial dispute and the 1962 war, while not forgotten, were put aside and a pragmatic economic-oriented focus adopted in the face of changing global realities. This bilateral reset led to the 1993 agreement on maintaining peace and tranquility on the border. The 1988 visit thus heralded a quarter century of an upswing in India-China relations. Although that phase may have ended, the initiative remains a high point of courageous and hard-headed diplomacy.

Saving Angkor Wat

Cambodia, 1980s

India's dispatch of an archaeological team to war-ravaged Cambodia to conserve the archaeological site of Angkor Wat was a great leap forward for Indian cultural diplomacy. Long before the 'Look East', 'Act East' or 'Indo Pacific' era—when Cambodia was at the centre of a civil war and in a geopolitical contestation with the Soviet Union and Vietnam on one side, China and the US on the other, and largely shunned by the western camp—India was among the few countries to recognise the nation. The Indic origins of the monuments made it appropriate for India to help, but this aggrieved the French, the former colonial masters, who had studied and documented the site since the 1890s. Leading western cultural institutions denigrated Indian conservation work at the site, but Indian diplomats held their nerve and Indian archaeologists have remained in Angkor ever since.



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